eldest son, Salim, to Abdun Nabi's school. The shaikh had great influence on the emperor, and great power, too, but he wasn't very popular.

It may not be surprising if Abul Fazl, knowing how Abdun Nabi and men like him had conspired against his father, is less than admiring of the sadr. Describing how Akbar gave Abdun Nabi his high post, Abul Fazl mutters the aside that the shaikh 'decked out his shop with hypocrisy'. Badauni, too, has little good to say about the judge – partly because of how Abdun Nabi dealt with his powers over grants of land to religious men.

It began well enough, writes Badauni, being dependent himself on such charitable *madad-ma'ash* grants and always appreciative of generosity – but things were soon 'reversed'. As he would do with agricultural land, Akbar ordered a comprehensive reappraisal of all madad-ma'ash grants in his realm, putting the fate of countless men in Abdun Nabi's hands. The shaikh did not take to this exponential increase in his powers with humility. Badauni describes him surrounded by petitioners, many of whom had already had to bribe his clerk, 'or make presents to his chamberlains, doorkeepers, and sweepers'. Even then, it was difficult to get your voice heard, and imperative to beg. Some even died in the heat of the throng; while Abdun Nabi sat unconcerned on his 'throne of pride', sometimes washing his hands and feet, and making sure to splash the dirty water 'on the head and face and garments' of the men around him – many of whom were powerful chiefs but, having come to plead a case, 'bore all this, and condescended to fawn on him, and flatter and toady him to his heart's content'.

Akbar didn't seem to notice. No other emperor, writes Badauni, had ever given such 'absolute power' to his sadr. The blaspheming brahmin of Mathura would change all that.[17]

The brahmin's guilt was undisputed, it seems; it was his punishment that divided the court. Some favoured death; others suggested a less drastic penalty, such as 'public exposure and fine'; while a third party, 'the ladies of the royal household', pressed the emperor to release the man. From 'regard to the Shaikh', writes Badauni, 'the King would not give his consent'. The case dragged on until Shaikh Abdun Nabi came to Akbar and asked for leave to execute the culprit. Akbar seems to have given him the same excuse he gave his queens. It was the sadr, he said, who was